

POLICY & REGULATION

Mamdani's EDC Picks: The Clock on City Land Deals Just Got More Expensive

Seven months without a leader means developers face a shorter window to execute on city-owned sites.

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A source-grounded Light Tower Insight. The complete note follows.

The most revealing fact about Mayor Zohran Mamdani's appointment of Anthony Shorris as CEO and Lina Khan as chair of the New York City Economic Development Corporation is not who got the jobs. It is that the jobs went unfilled for more than seven months.

Seven months is not a transition period. It is a signal that the administration was deciding what the EDC should be before deciding who should run it. That delay has a cost, and it is denominated in time — the one input developers cannot manufacture.

The EDC controls city-owned land. It selects developers for public-private partnerships. It administers programs like the \$1 billion LifeSci NYC initiative, which has already struggled to gain momentum. For seven months, those functions operated without a permanent leader. Deals that needed a signature did not get one. RFPs that needed a strategic direction did not get issued. The clock on every pending city land transaction kept running, but the person who could move it forward was not in place.

Time is not a neutral backdrop in development. It is the most expensive ingredient in the capital stack. Every month of delay on a city land deal pushes out the construction start, the lease-up, the stabilization, and the refinancing. For a developer carrying pre-development costs, soft costs, and a ticking option on the site, seven months of leadership vacuum is not an administrative inconvenience. It is a direct hit to project-level returns.

Now the question is what Shorris and Khan will do with the time they have left in this mayoral term. Shorris brings deep city government experience — first deputy mayor under de Blasio, budget official under Koch, head of the Port Authority. He knows how the machinery works. Khan brings a reputation for aggressive antitrust enforcement from her tenure as FTC chair under Biden. Her appointment signals that the EDC will not simply be a deal facilitator. It will be an agency that asks whether a transaction serves economic justice, not just economic growth.

Mamdani's language at the press conference was explicit: economic development and economic justice must go hand in hand. That is a policy statement, but it is also a capital markets signal.

Developers who underwrite city land deals based on the old EDC playbook — speed, certainty, minimal community conditions — should expect a different set of terms. The agency's mission is being reoriented toward poverty reduction, not just job creation and investment attraction.

That reorientation will show up in the structure of future RFPs. The Harlem lot released this week, offered at no cost for a 140-unit mixed-income development, is a preview. Free land is a powerful subsidy, but it comes with conditions: income restrictions, community benefits, longer timelines. Developers who take that deal are trading basis for complexity. The question is whether the math works at the returns their capital partners require.

For the real estate industry, the reaction has been cautiously positive. REBNY President James Whelan praised Shorris as a thoughtful, experienced leader. That is the public statement. The private calculation is more nuanced: Shorris knows the city, but he also knows that his mandate is to deliver projects that meet a new standard of economic justice. That standard will be negotiated deal by deal, and the negotiation will take time.

Khan's role as chair adds another layer. Her reputation is for challenging concentrated power, not for speeding up permitting. Developers should expect the EDC to scrutinize not just the financial terms of a deal, but the market structure it reinforces. A project that consolidates too much control in one developer, or that displaces existing tenants without a clear plan for their return, will face a harder path.

The market should test this: how long does it take for the first major city land RFP to close under the new leadership? If the timeline stretches beyond what developers and their lenders can underwrite, the cost of that time will show up in fewer bids, higher required returns, or both. If the EDC moves quickly, it will signal that the administration understands the arithmetic of development: time is money, and the city cannot afford to waste either.

The next phase of New York's development cycle will not be defined by who owns the best site. It will be defined by who can execute within the city's new timeline. That timeline just got a leader. The clock is now running.

SOURCES

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